Worked examples

Showing a complete solution

Use a worked example when students need to see the full structure of a successful response before attempting a complex task. Make the important decisions and criteria visible.

How to do it well

1 Clarify the task. State what successful performance looks like and confirm the prerequisites students need.

2 Present the complete example. Show the response in a clear sequence or structure, with relevant workings and criteria.

3 Explain consequential choices. Point to where the method, evidence or feature satisfies the task and why an alternative would fail.

4 Rehearse the structure. Ask students to explain a step, compare a near-miss or complete a partly worked related example.

5 Hand over the method. Give a fresh independent task and remove the model when students can use the underlying structure without it.

What this sounds like

“This is a complete answer. Notice the claim, evidence and explanation. We will identify what each part does, then complete a different answer with the final section missing.”

Classroom example. A Business Studies worked example shows the complete response structure, calculations and interpretation. The teacher identifies why each part is needed, then contrasts a near-miss. Pupils complete a different example with the final section missing before attempting the whole response independently. The complete model provides a route into the demand.

Top tips that make the technique work

Choose a representative example. The model should expose the method students need, without an exceptional trick or distracting complexity.

Include the reasoning. A correct sequence with no rationale can encourage superficial copying.

Keep the layout transferable. Use a clear structure students can apply to another response.

Compare with a near-miss. A small error can reveal why the successful step is necessary.

Bridge to completion problems. Remove selected final steps before expecting the whole process independently.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Show the complete method and its key decisions.	A polished answer with no explanation of its structure.
Move to a distinct related example.	Assuming copying the model establishes independent competence.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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